Pairing & Mobbing

Choose a style, rotate partners, agree how sessions run, and use pairing to spread skills across the team.

Manage Flow · Pair Programming · Mob / Ensemble Programming · Pair Stair · Spread Skills

WORKED EXAMPLE · FICTIONAL TEAM

TEAM: Basket team

DATE: 12 May

1 Styles

PICK ONE PER SESSION · WORKS FOR CODE, TESTS, ANALYSIS AND DESIGN

Driver / Navigator

One types (driver), one thinks ahead and reviews (navigator). Swap roles every 15–30 minutes.

Use it for: risky payments code

Swap every: 20 minutes

Ping-Pong

A writes a failing test, B makes it pass and writes the next test. Great with test-driven development.

Use it for: new features, test first

Swap every: each test

Strong-Style

"For an idea to go from your head into the computer, it must go through someone else's hands."

Use it for: teaching Ravi the codebase

Swap every: 15 minutes

Mob / Ensemble

The whole group, one keyboard. The driver rotates every few minutes. Ideal for swarming.

Use it for: swarms and tricky bugs

Swap every: 10 minutes

2 Pair Stair

TALLY EACH PAIRING · SPREAD IT OUT

	P1	P2	P3	P4	P5	P6	P7	P8
P1 Priya								
P2 Sam	/							
P3 Jo		////						
P4 Alex	//	//	/					
P5 Mei	///		///					
P6 Tom				/				
P7 Ravi		///	//	//				
P8								

Write names on the left. Add a tally where two people pair. Empty cells = pairs to try.

3 Session Agreements

We pair or mob by default on: payments; new joiners' work

We work solo on: small fixes, spikes

Swap roles every (min): 20

Take a break every (min): 50

Rotate partners every: iteration

Setup & tools: big screen, shared editor

- [x] Anyone can call a break or a swap
- [x] Navigators ask questions, not orders

4 Skills to Spread

FROM THE SKILLS MATRIX

SKILL	LEARNER	TEACHER	PAIR / MOB
Payments	Jo	Sam	pair
Test automation	Ravi	Alex	ping-pong
Data	Tom	Priya	pair
Cloud, CI/CD	Alex	Platform	mob

5 This Week's Pairs

WORK ITEM	WHO	STYLE
Substitute suggestions	Sam + Jo	driver / navigator
Reorder test suite	Ravi + Alex	ping-pong

6 Quick Retro

AFTER A SESSION OR AT THE END OF THE WEEK

What worked?

- Jo now reviews payments code
- fewer review waits

What was hard?

- pairing all day is tiring
- the mob felt slow at first

Next time we'll…

- a break every 50 minutes
- rotate pairs on Mondays

"Who haven't we paired with yet, and what could we learn from each other?"

"What would finish faster if two of us worked on it?"

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